



ENG103: Research Writing Techniques

Paragraph Research Writing

Session outline

- The factors that differentiate research writing from general essay writing
- The core of a research main body paragraph
- The Topic Sentence
- The Supporting Sentences
- The Concluding Sentence

The factors that differentiate research writing from general essay writing

Both general essay writing and research writing discuss ideas (e.g. a solution to a problem) and express opinions (e.g., an explanation or judgment of an event). However, the ideas and opinions in research writing are supported with appropriate **evidence**, while this is not always the case with general essay writing.

The **evidence** that can be used in research writing is varied and typically falls into one of two categories, which are **secondary research** and **primary research**.

Secondary research: refers to an author's use of another researcher's information to support or reach an idea or opinion

Primary research: refers to an author's creation of information to support or reach an idea or opinion.

The core of a research main body paragraph

Introductions and conclusions in general and research essays are similar. They both use the introduction to outline the focus of the essay and to present the thesis statement. Likewise, they both use the conclusion to present a summary of the main points discussed. However, it is the main body paragraphs in research essays that differ significantly from general essays. Both use main body paragraphs to present an idea (or an opinion) but in addition to this research essays support the idea with appropriate secondary or primary research.

Moreover, a core component of a research paragraph is its formation. In this regard, Oshima and Hogue (1999) explain that:

A **paragraph** is a group of related sentences that discuss one (and usually only one) main idea. A paragraph can be as short as one sentence or as long as ten sentences. The number of sentences is unimportant; however, the paragraph should be long enough to develop the main idea clearly (p. 2).

However, is there a real need to segment a text into paragraphs, and “can't we just have a continues text”?

A key benefit of segmenting a text into paragraphs is that it allows for an easier delivery of related, but different ideas.

The core of a research main body paragraph

A paragraph is formed from three major components:

- 1) A topic sentence (essential)
- 2) Supporting sentences (essential)
- 3) A concluding sentence (optional)

However, it is important to note this is a general guide and on occasions it may be necessary to modify or deviate from these three major components.

The Topic Sentence

The topic sentence indicates the main topic that will be discussed in the paragraph. Moreover, it not only highlights the main topic of the paragraph, but it also outlines the remit of the area of discussion. This specific area is called the 'controlling idea', which makes a specific comment (in most cases a claim) about the topic:

Topic

Controlling idea

John Temper, the new CEO of Block Media, in line with previous CEOs, continues with attempts to destabilize Block Media's main competitor, Raycom Entertainment.

The Topic Sentence

Reviewing the function of a topic sentence:

A topic sentence should be the most general statement in the paragraph. It should only present one main idea without giving any specific details. The idea could be a significant claim, but because the rest of the paragraph will function to support it there is not a need to present evidence in the topic sentence. Moreover, a topic sentence must not be too general to render it meaningless, while at the same time it must not be too specific.

Which sentence is more appropriate as a topic sentence?

- The Turkish phrase *maalesef* (meaning “unfortunately”) is a corruption of the Arabic **مأسفة** **مأسفة**.
- The Arabic origin of many Turkish words is not always obvious.
- Languages copy different languages.

The Supporting Sentences

Supporting sentences develop the topic sentence, which is common with general essay paragraphs. However, unique to research writing the supporting sentences offer evidence to support its claims, which can involve giving reasons, empirical examples, scholarly views, and in cases primary research findings. Below is an illustration of how supporting sentences work, with reference to the previous example:

It is the case that since Block Media's creation in 1977 it has supported various pro-free speech groups as well as opposition groups that lobby the government for more censorship of audio-visual content. For example, Coahaagen (1995) argues that "Block Media since the 1970s has supported various often competing media advocacy groups that only have had one thing in common, they all have been against Raycom Entertainment" (p. 245). Moreover, Quaid (2004) has identified that since 1990 successive Block Media administrations have increased their budget to finance groups opposed to Raycom Entertainment. But what is most intriguing is that he asserts that, "the increase in budget is in proportion to the increase in market profits of Raycom Entertainment in that the more profit Raycom Entertainment makes the more the Block Media invests to destabilize it" (p. 56). In line with this historical trend, John Temper explained in a New York Times interview, in February 2019, he would direct Block Media to financially support Peta Democratic, which is a lobby group calling for less governmental control over media content (Dillinger, 2019). However, during the same period it was disclosed, in a Block Media memo (Block Media, 2019), that John Temper's administration was also funding a conservative movement who is in opposition not only to the Raycom Entertainment, but also the erosion of censorship laws. Commenting on this observation Lull (2019) states that "what at first sight may seem paradoxical and contradictory is in fact very coherent and deliberate and is an embodiment of the maxim, the enemy of my enemy is my friend" (p. 175).

The Supporting Sentences

Reviewing the function of supporting sentences:

Supporting sentences function to justify the claim or idea put forward in the topic sentence. They can be very specific and can rely on empirical data as well as secondary sources. A good practice is to firstly present a secondary source (a scholarly view) then support this with actual empirical examples. However, it is important to include your own explanations and explorations of an idea; do NOT just rely on the views of others and allow your voice to be heard.

Which sentence is more appropriate as a supporting sentence?

- Consequently, students should give equal importance to good structuring as they do to developing ideas.
- Writing a successful essay relies more on following a structure than having good ideas.
- A survey of 218 university professors conducted by Bickle (1976) found that 78% of correspondents favored clear structuring over good ideas when awarding marks.

The Concluding Sentence

The concluding sentence brings the paragraph to an end while reiterating the topic, the controlling idea and highlighting the most important points, which were raised. However, it is not always necessary to write a concluding sentence especially for short paragraphs and paragraphs which form part of a wider argument and are intrinsically connected to their surrounding paragraphs.

The following can be used as end of paragraph signals.

- (Followed by a comma) Finally,... As a result,... In conclusion,... Indeed,... In summary,... In brief,... Therefore, ... In short, ... Thus,...
- (Not followed by a comma) We can see that... It is clear that... These examples show that... There can be no doubt that... The evidence suggests that...

Below is a conclusion works with reference to the previous example:

In conclusion, John Temper's support of two opposing media lobby groups is an embodiment of a continued effort by successive Block Media leaderships to destabilize Raycom Entertainment.

The Concluding Sentence

Reviewing the function of concluding sentence:

In essence, the concluding sentence marks the end of the paragraph, while presenting an opportunity to stress the main idea presented in the paragraph.

- **Which sentence is more appropriate as a concluding sentence?**
- At the end of the day, we all need to breathe clean air.
- Therefore, the notion that clean air effects human cognition is not only intuitive but is supported by scientific evidence and should be a matter of concern.
- Montana (1982) found that children at schools located near busy roads gained knowledge at a significantly slower rate compared to children who studied in schools which were situated in rural areas.

Paragraph Example

John Temper, the new CEO of Block Media, in line with previous CEOs, continues with attempts to destabilize Block Media's main competitor, Raycom Entertainment. It is the case that since Block Media's creation in 1972 it has supported various pro-free speech groups as well as opposition groups that lobby the government for more censorship of audio-visual content. For example, Coahaagen (1995) argues that "Block Media since the 1970s has supported various often competing media advocacy groups that only have had one thing in common, they all have been against Raycom Entertainment" (p. 245). Moreover, Quaid (2004) has identified that since 1990 successive Block Media administrations have increased their budget to finance groups opposed to Raycom Entertainment. But what is most intriguing is that he asserts that, "the increase in budget is in proportion to the increase in market profits of Raycom Entertainment in that the more profit Raycom Entertainment makes the more the Block Media invests to destabilize it" (p. 56). In line with this historical trend, John Temper explained in a New York Times interview, in February 2019, he would direct Block Media to financially support Peta Democratic, which is a lobby group calling for less governmental control over media content (Dillinger, 2019). However, during the same period it was disclosed, in a Block Media memo (Block Media, 2019), that John Temper's administration was also funding a conservative movement who is in opposition not only to the Raycom Entertainment, but also the erosion of censorship laws. Commenting on this observation Lull (2019) states that "what at first sight may seem paradoxical and contradictory is in fact very coherent and deliberate and is an embodiment of the maxim, the enemy of my enemy is my friend" (p. 175). In conclusion, John Temper's support of two opposing media lobby groups is an embodiment of a continued effort by successive Block Media leaderships to destabilize Raycom Entertainment.

Class exercise 1

- 1) Working in your groups review the below paragraph and discuss how well it confirms to what you have been taught thus far. Also, identify areas it can be improved.
- 2) Present your findings to the class.

The reason there is such a reliance on human interpretation to derive meaning from a text is because language has a degree of inherent ambiguity which requires the reader to make inferences based on extralinguistic assumptions, sometimes unconsciously and spontaneously. This is the primary reason why computers since the very inception of machine translation (MT) in the late 1940s have been unable to consistently produce 'complete' translations without human assistance (see for example appendix III Bar-Hillel 1960). Moreover, Al-Shabab (2016) suggests that various elements beyond language conventions contribute to the comprehension of language. He refers to these as the 'interpretive frame', which consists of six separate elements: 'being', 'environment', 'understanding', 'experience' (knowledge), 'assertion', and 'identity'. It is important to note that this, at a level, resembles the interpretive theory of translation, which contends that "[...] there cannot be effective translation without interpretation" (Lederer, 2014 p. 5). Moreover, Al-Shabab contends that not only is the interpretive frame essential in the formulation of meaning, but without it the span of potential meanings is infinite. From this perspective, language is not only inherently ambiguous, but it also has a degree of plasticity which can be exploited to impose a specific meaning on a text.

Class exercise 2

1) Working in your groups write a paragraph related to one of the following subjects: peace, war, birth, death, education, manipulation, science, technology, language and travel.

Use the following outline to aid you:

Topic sentence:

First supporting sentence:

Second supporting sentence:

Third supporting sentence:

Fourth supporting sentence:

Concluding sentence:

2) Once complete email your paragraph and to me (one email per group).

References

Oshima, A., & Hogue, A. (2006) *Writing Academic English* (4th ed.). Pearson/Longman.